



IN A SOUP: Veterinarians check birds in Birbhum in West Bengal

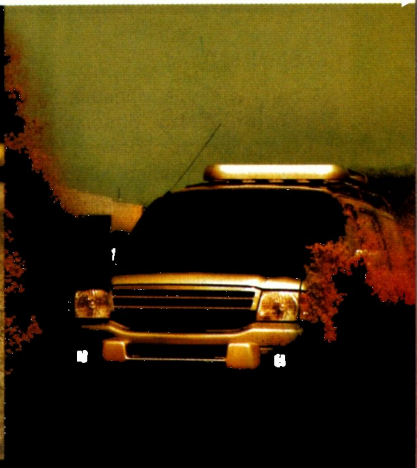
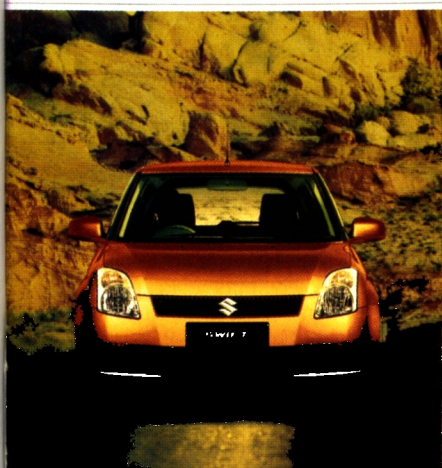
Epizootics or the World Organisation of Animal Health has put India on the list of bird flu affected countries since January 16. Bearing the impact are the 800-odd poultry farms in Namakkal in Tamil Nadu which account for nine of 10 eggs exported. Exports have come down from 60 lakh to 35 lakh eggs a day since then. Ironically, the outbreak was reported a month after the country declared itself free of the virus at the international ministerial conference on avian and pandemic influenza in Delhi and became, for the first time, a donor to fight the menace.

The National Egg Coordination Committee (NECC), which represents the interests of the poultry industry, wants the Centre to hasten the zoning process to ensure that poultry exports from areas unaffected by the flu continue unhindered. "The Government should step in immediately to create exclusive poultry zones and facilitate exports of products," says Anuradha Desai, chairperson, NECC and Venkateswara Hatcheries. Even a limited outbreak can affect the poultry industry at the

national level, which provides employment to 3.2 million people and contributes Rs 36,000 crore to the gross national product.

While containment is a priority, the task of identifying the strain and comparing it with samples from earlier outbreaks to check for mutation is equally important. The H5N1 strain is so far limited to birds and has not yet jumped on to human beings but can exchange genes with a human flu strain and produce a contagious new germ. Moreover, little progress has been reported on the indigenous production of a vaccine.

Bird flu has infected 350 people in 14 countries and killed 218 since 2003. It has shown a fatality rate of over 61 per cent in humans. Fortunately for India, despite three outbreaks in two years, there have been no human casualties so far. Even now all human samples from West Bengal, screened by the National Institute of Communicable Diseases, Delhi, have tested negative. But this is little consolation. If adequate containment measures are not taken, there is a risk of the pandemic striking the country and endangering much more than what it has now. ■



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